

Psalms 143

Hear My Prayer, O Lord

Hear my prayer, O Lord, give ear to my supplications: in thy faithfulness answer me
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Hear my prayer, O LORD, give ear to my supplications: in thy faithfulness answer me, and in thy righteousness.
- 2 And enter not into judgment with thy servant: for in thy sight shall no man living be justified.
- 3 For the enemy hath persecuted my soul; he hath smitten my life down to the ground; he hath made me to dwell in darkness, as those that have been long dead.
- 4 Therefore is my spirit overwhelmed within me; my heart within me is desolate.
- 5 I remember the days of old; I meditate on all thy works; I muse on the work of thy hands.
- 6 I stretch forth my hands unto thee: my soul thirsteth after thee, as a thirsty land. Selah.
- 7 Hear me speedily, O LORD: my spirit faileth: hide not thy face from me, lest I be like unto them that go down into the pit.
- 8 Cause me to hear thy lovingkindness in the morning; for in thee do I trust: cause me to know the way wherein I should walk; for I lift up my soul unto thee.
- 9 Deliver me, O LORD, from mine enemies: I flee unto thee to hide me.
- 10 Teach me to do thy will; for thou art my God: thy spirit is good; lead me into the land of uprightness.
- 11 Quicken me, O LORD, for thy name's sake: for thy righteousness' sake bring my soul out of trouble.
- 12 And of thy mercy cut off mine enemies, and destroy all them that afflict my soul: for I am thy servant.

2 · CONTEXT

One of the traditional penitential psalms, Psalm 143 combines urgent petition under pursuit with humble acknowledgment that no one, including David himself, could be justified by his own righteousness before God. It moves from present distress, through remembered meditation on God's past works, to a request not merely for rescue but for guidance into right living. Henry treats its closing plea to be taught God's will as evidence that David seeks more than relief—he seeks ongoing direction.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

David asks God to hear his prayer and answer in faithfulness and righteousness, immediately qualifying the request: do not enter into judgment with your servant, for no one living could be justified on the merits of their own righteousness. The enemy has persecuted his soul, struck his life down to the ground, and his spirit is overwhelmed within him.

Verse 5-6

In the midst of distress, David deliberately remembers days of old, meditates on all of God's works, and considers what His hands have done. His soul thirsts for God like dry land thirsts for rain—an image of desperate, physical longing, not polite religious sentiment.

Verse 7-9

Urgency intensifies: hear me speedily, do not hide your face, lest I become like those who go down to the pit. David asks to hear of God's lovingkindness in the morning, to be taught the way he should walk since his soul is lifted up to God, and to be delivered from his enemies and hidden from them.

Verse 10-12

The closing petitions move beyond mere rescue: teach me to do your will, since you are my God; let your good spirit lead me into a level, upright path. He asks to be revived and kept alive for God's own name's sake, brought out of trouble, and delivered from enemies, closing with the simple identification: I am your servant.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Honest prayer under pressure holds together urgent petition for rescue, humble acknowledgment that no one is righteous enough to demand vindication, and a deeper request for ongoing guidance rather than mere relief. David's thirst for God, expressed through deliberate remembrance of past works, shows that crisis can become the occasion for renewed dependence rather than only

complaint.

Application for life today.

When you pray urgently for deliverance, follow David's pattern by also acknowledging honestly, as in verse 2, that you cannot claim to deserve rescue on the basis of your own righteousness. Build a deliberate practice of remembering God's past works, as verse 5 describes, especially when current circumstances offer no comfort of their own. Ask for more than relief in your next hard prayer—request, as verse 10 does, to be taught God's will and led in an upright path, not merely rescued from the immediate trouble.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does David's honest admission in verse 2—that no one is justified by their own righteousness—shape the way you approach God in your own urgent prayers?

2. What specific past work of God could you deliberately remember and meditate on, as in verse 5, during a current dry or difficult season?

3. Where do you need to ask God not just for rescue but for guidance—'teach me to do thy will' (v. 10)—in a situation you are currently praying about?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).